station and a plutonium device was buried somewhere under the snow and earth on the Nanda Devi slopes. But he categorically denied the accusation made by Howard Kohn in his article that Indira Gandhi was not kept in the loop and that the IB was tricked into setting up the monitoring station. Desai said:

In the light of the international situation prevailing at that time and the scientific developments which were taking place both far and near, it was decided by the Government of India and the Government of the United States at the highest level that a remote sensing device with nuclear power pack should be installed near the highest point on Nanda Devi with the object of securing information about the missile developments. Accordingly, a mountaineering expedition manned only by Indian mountaineers went up the Nanda Devi followed by a joint Indo-American expedition scientifically equipped with the device with a view to installing it at a height of 25,000 feet. When the expedition was approaching the summit, it was overtaken by a blizzard, which made further ascent impossible, and facing fatal hazards to the party, they were obliged to retreat to the lower camp at a height of 23,000 feet. In precipitate descent under very trying and exacting conditions, they had to leave the power pack securely cached. With the onslaught of winter, no attempt to locate and retrieve the device was immediately possible and had to be postponed. Another expedition was mounted in May 1966 with the intention of retrieving and installing the device. However, the expedition party on arrival at the areas discovered that a major avalanche had occurred around the area and the device could not be located. In May 1967, a new device was taken to the same area and was duly installed on a neighbouring peak. This